remained behind, however, for the next several decades. The task of cleaning out the Guomindang fell on the Burmese military under Ne Win. The success of the military operations gave the fledging military much-needed legitimacy. From the Burmese perspective, this was a wake-up call to create a bigger and better army. High-ranking members of the Burmese military were sent aboard for study and training in areas such as Israel, Yugoslavia, and Western Europe.

Eventually, the United States backed the Burmese military action against the Guomindang. The United States realized that Burma's neutrality in the Cold War took precedent over a futile attempt to prop up an insurgency that had no real chance of making significant progress against the People's Liberation Army in China. The neutrality of Burma was enhanced by U Nu's role in the Bandung Conference of 1955, which formulated the Non-Aligned Movement.

DEMOCRATIC PROGRESS AND REGRESSION: 1956–1962

The 1956 elections were dominated by the AFPFL. The National United Front was dealt an embarrassing defeat. U Nu decided to step down as prime minister for one year as he attempted to reunite the party. Ba Swe took over the temporary helm of the party with an agenda to restore law and order to Burma. U Nu returned as prime minister in February 1957, but the AFPFL was fractured beyond repair.

The AFPFL split in 1958 over the issue was both institutional and personal, according to historian Charney. The legacy of Aung San was wearing off nearly a decade after his assassination. The insurgency upheaval and rebellions probably helped to keep the party together for longer than it would have under different circumstances. The internal tension was heightened following the suppression of the insurgency movements. U Nu and Thakin Tin led the “clean” AFPFL faction. Kyaw Nyein and Ba Swe led the “stable” faction. The stable faction was actually the larger group because of the backing from the socialist in Burma. U Nu countered the growing support for the stable faction by pardoning prisoners, opening the door to greater autonomy for states, and legalizing outlawed movements such as the communist party. Political and military organizations chose sides, leading to intense bickering and infighting. The